



Colour Theory

A detailed colour guide

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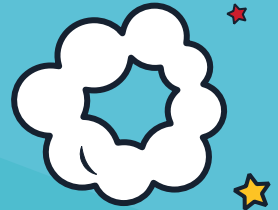
Colour Models

What is Colour?

Colour is essentially a perception; a wavelength of light reflected which our brain in turn interprets as a phenomenon called light.

Colour is the place where
our brain and the universe
meet.

-Paul Klee



01

Colour Theory

What is colour theory?



Art or Science?

Art

- A logical structure to everyday sightings.
- Factors the messages that colour communicates.
- Best practices for designing harmonious combinations.

Science

- Explains how humans perceive colour.
- Explains how colours can be replicated in printing/computers.
- The idea that specific colours are more appealing to the human eye.

Why is Colour Theory so important?

Given that 90% of the information sent to our brains is visual, Colour theory becomes then critical for conveying our message confidently and influencing our audience.



02

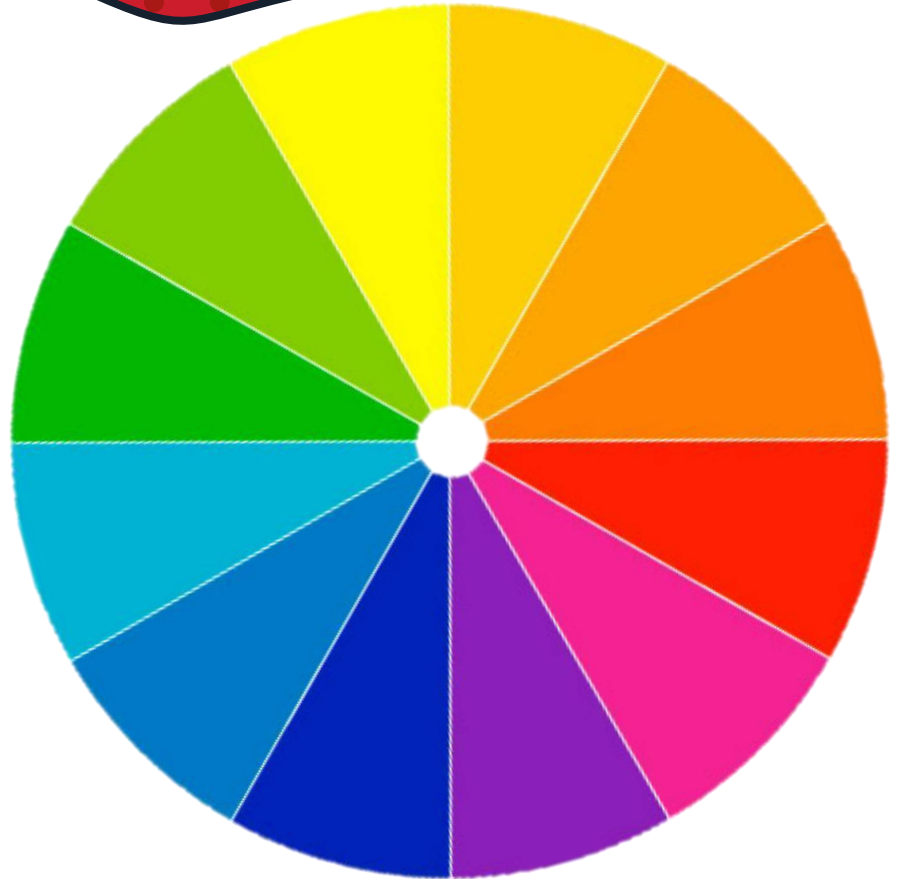
Colour Wheel

Understanding the spectrum.



COLOUR WHEEL THEORY

Mapped by Sir Isaac Newton in 1666, we call this circle the colour wheel. It has 12 basic colours forming the spectrum.



Today there are **3** colour wheels;
one for each colour model,
however the relations between
colours remain the same.

Artists always refer to a colour
wheel when choosing a colour
scheme.



How do colours relate to each other?



Primary Colours



Primary +
Secondary



Primary +
Secondary + Tertiary



03

Colour
Properties



Properties of Colour



HUE

The pure form of any colour.



VALUE

How pure the appearance of colour is.

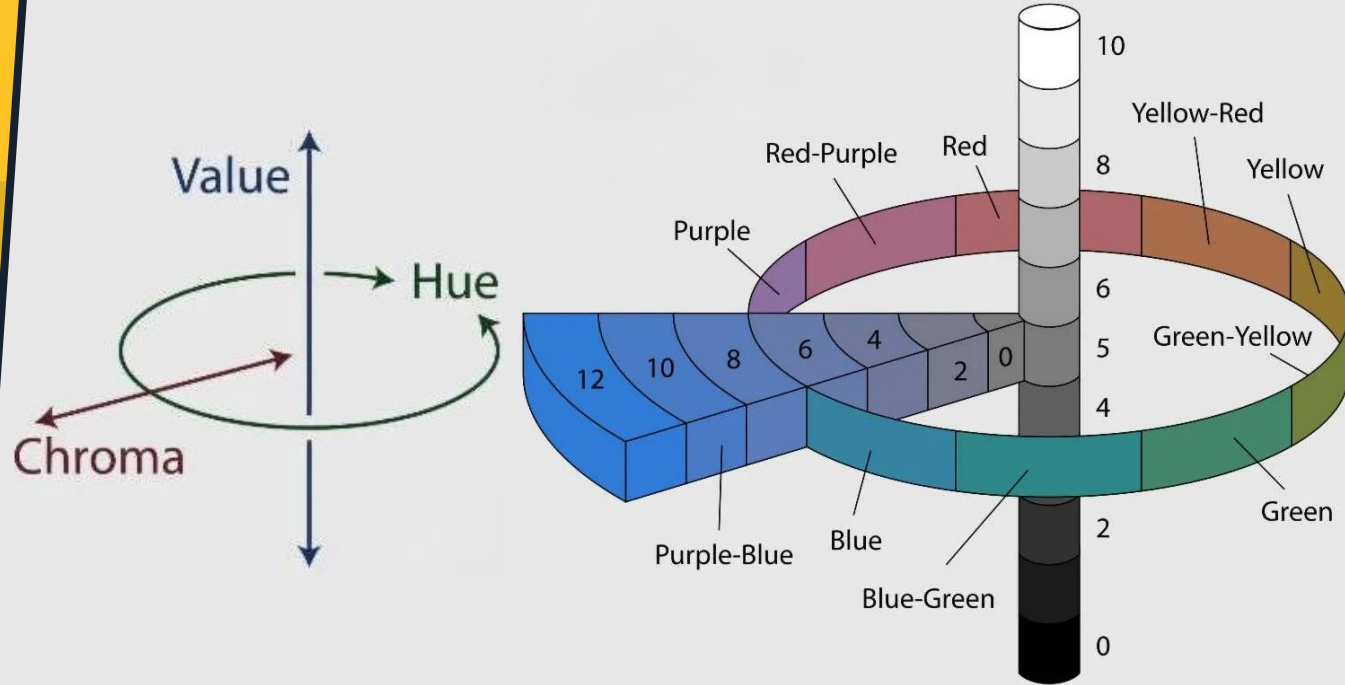


CHROMA

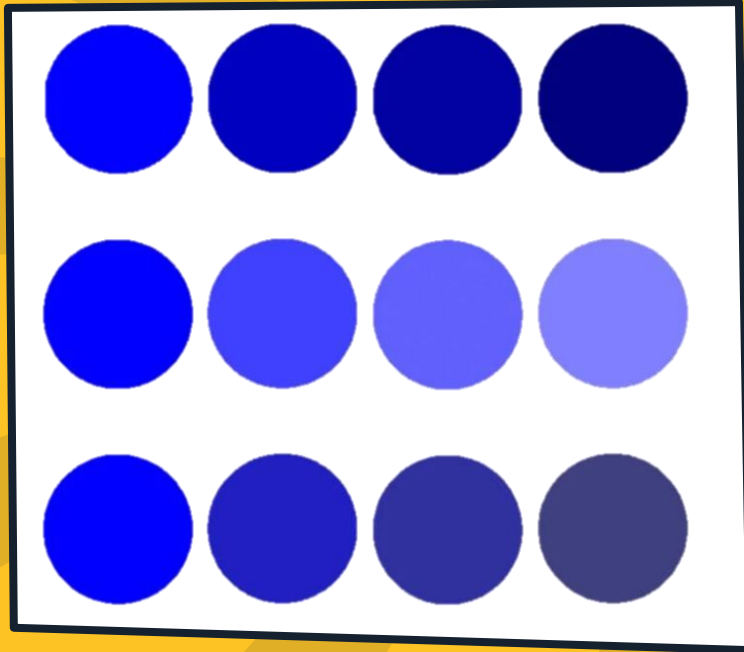
How pale or saturated the colour is.



The Munsell Colour System



Controlling the Value of a Colour



SHADE

Colour + Black

TINT

Colour + White

TONE

Colour + Gray

WARM

The Temperature of a colour

Whether we realize it or not, our brain registers some colours as warm and others as cool.

We can basically draw a line down the middle of a colour wheel to divide it.

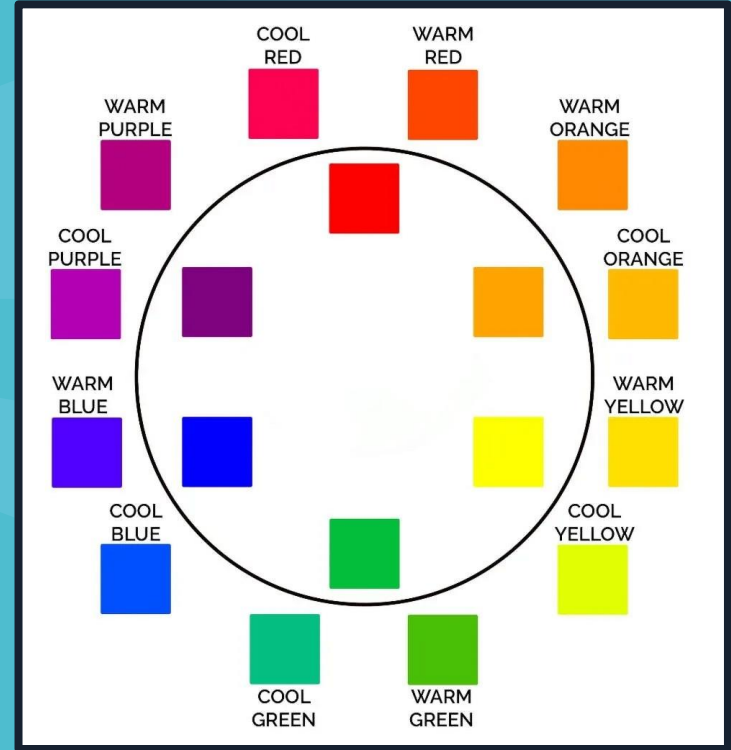
COOL



Colours VS. Undertones

It may seem as simple as saying Reds, Yellows, & Oranges are **Warm**, while Blues, Greens, & Purples are **Cool**.

However, each colour has what we call an **Undertone**, meaning you could have cool oranges or warm reds.





04

Colour Schemes

Creating harmonies that are
pleasing to the eye.

Colour Schemes / Harmonies

Monochromatic



Analogous



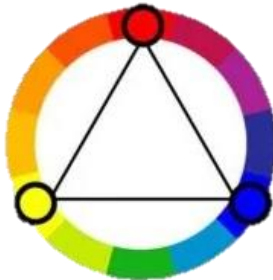
Complementary



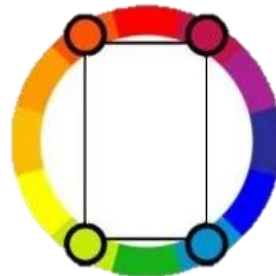
Split-Compliment



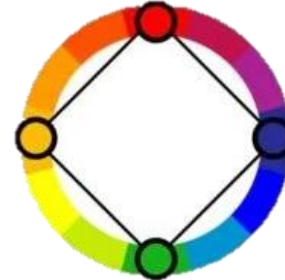
Triadic



Tetradic



Square



Analogous



- RED
- ORANGE
- YELLOW

Tetradic



- YELLOW
- GREEN
- ORANGE
- PURPLE

Complimentary



- RED

- GREEN

Monochromatic



- GREEN

Split-Compliment



- BLUE GREEN

- BLUE VIOLET

- ORANGE

Triadic



- RED
- BLUE
- YELLOW

Square

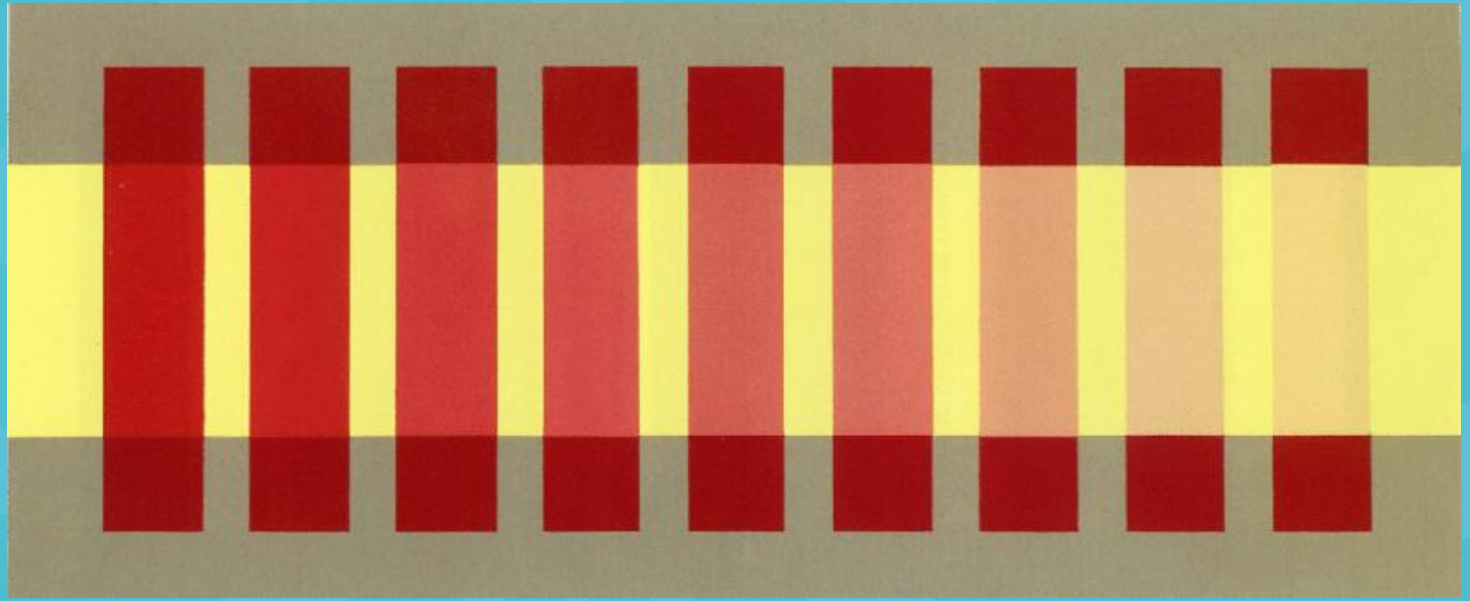


- YELLOW
- BLUE GREEN
- RED ORANGE
- PURPLE



Working with colours and understanding the relations between them, we can create cool illusions.

For example, all of these spheres, are exactly the same colour.



You can even create
the illusion of
transparency or space.



05

Psychology of
Colour

Black



Positive

- Power
- Mystery
- Elegance
- Sophistication
- Strength

Negative

- Sadness
- Menacing
- Scary
- Death
- Mourning

White



Positive

- Clean
- Pure
- Safe
- Sterile
- Calm

Negative

- Blank
- Stark
- Cold
- Isolated
- Empty

Grey



Positive

- Diplomatic
- Intellectual
- Elegant
- Serious
- Wisdom

Negative

- Neutral
- Depressed
- Impartial
- Gloom
- Dull

Brown



Positive

- Comfortable
- Simple
- Natural
- Warm
- Homely

Negative

- Boring
- Death
- Cheap
- Dormant
- Dirty

Red



Positive

- Bold
- Attractive
- Passion
- Energy
- Excitement

Negative

- Anger
- Injury
- Danger
- Anxiety
- Shame

Blue



Positive

- Calm
- Relaxed
- Tranquil
- Peaceful
- Friendly

Negative

- Depression
- Cold
- Fear
- Sadness
- Aloof

Green



Positive

- Nature
- Restful
- Harmony
- Trustworthy
- Balance

Negative

- Envy
- Possessiveness
- Materialism
- Jealousy
- Greed

Yellow



Positive

- Warm
- Happy
- Spontaneous
- Creativity
- Enlightenment

Negative

- Madness
- Caution
- Stressful
- Illness
- Egotism

Purple



Positive

- Power
- Nobility
- Luxury
- Spiritual
- Grace

Negative

- Pompous
- Conceited
- Unstable
- Decadent
- Immature

Orange



Positive

- Energetic
- Enthusiasm
- Excitement
- Lively
- Stimulating

Negative

- Rude
- Crass
- Cheap
- Superficial
- Unsociable

Pink



Positive

- Nurturing
- Playful
- Soft
- Innocent
- Nostalgic

Negative

- Timid
- Needy
- Naïve
- Passive
- Childish

How To Use Colour

Understand
your audience

01

02

Set a mood

Pick a few
Colours

03

04

Consider the
context

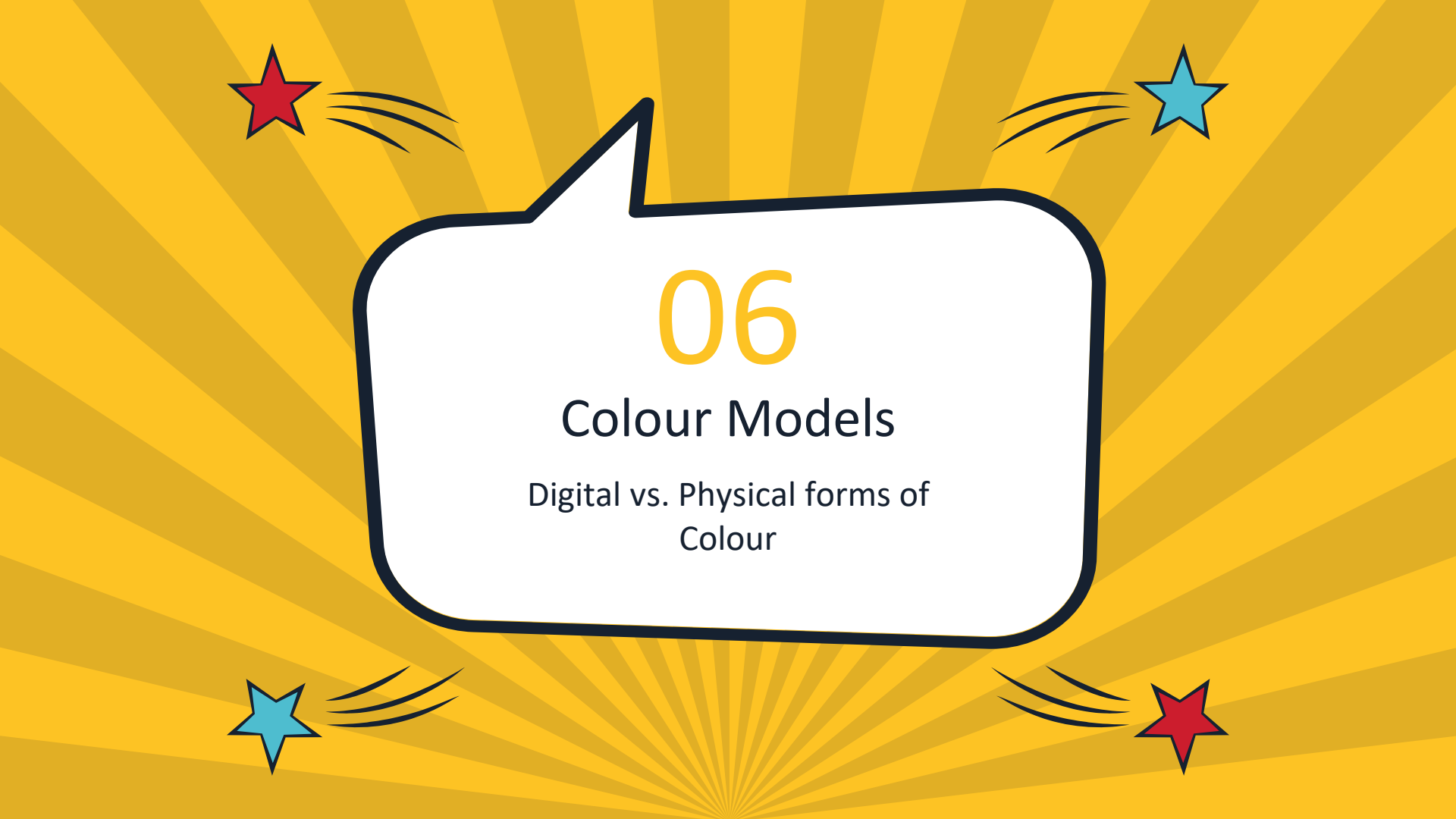
Use the
60-30-10 rule

05

06

Draft your
design





06

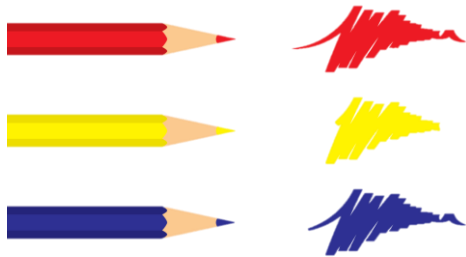
Colour Models

Digital vs. Physical forms of
Colour

Colour Models

RYB

- The 'Traditional' colour theory still used in mixing paints.
- A subtractive model; starting with white then subtracting reflected light.



RGB

- The model used by all electronic screens like TVs and Computers.
- An additive colour model; beginning with black then applying light sources.



CMYK

- The colour on any physical printed surface.
- A subtractive mixing model; removing light from paper by adding pigmented ink to it.



Glossary

Accent	Additional colors that generally contrast or complement.
Neutral	Neutral colors are muted shades that lack color but often have underlying hues.
Saturation	The intensity of color in an image.
Undertone	It refers to a subdued or muted tone of color.
Wavelength	The distance over which the wave's shape repeats.

Thank You For Your Time!

Do you have any questions?

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